

Chapter 170-3

Before going to sleep, Xu Qingzhu took out the eye mask she had bought a few days ago from the drawer, put it on, and lay in bed waiting for Liang Shi.

When Liang Shi came back after washing up, she saw Xu Qingzhu lying there in a white off-shoulder dress, wearing an eye mask, breathing evenly—it sounded like she was asleep.

Liang Shi lightened her footsteps, carefully walked in, got into bed, and turned off the light.

But the moment the light went off, it turned back on again.

"You're not asleep?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu didn't remove the eye mask. "I was waiting for you."

"I'm back," Liang Shi said. "Go to sleep."

"What time are you leaving tomorrow?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

"Nine o'clock."

"That should be fine then."

Liang Shi said, "By the time I get there, it'll be evening. I won't be able to reply to your messages while I'm on the plane."

Xu Qingzhu burrowed into her arms. "I know."

No matter how you listened, there was a hint of unhappiness in her voice.

"What's wrong?" Liang Shi's hand fell on her back, gently stroking. "Unhappy?"

"We're going to be in a long-distance relationship—how could I possibly be happy?" Xu Qingzhu scoffed lightly. "Are you feeling pleased? Finally able to get rid of me."

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi bit her lip lightly. "Why are you saying such angry words?"

"Then... coax me." Xu Qingzhu leaned close to her ear, her words barely more than a breath.

Liang Shi smiled softly but held back from laughing out loud. "How should I coax you?"

"Coax me properly," Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi kissed her lips. "Is this okay?"

Xu Qingzhu: ".....So perfunctory."

She took off the eye mask. "I'm not pretending to sleep anymore. I'm too annoyed to fall asleep."

Her eyes met Liang Shi's directly, with the eye mask still resting on her nose bridge.

After becoming pregnant, she had become somewhat sensitive to light, so she wore an eye mask to sleep every night.

Liang Shi stared at her intently, then pulled her onto herself in one motion.

Liang Shi's hand rested on her neck. "Then tonight..."

Her voice paused slightly: "I'm yours for the picking."¹

After saying this, her ears were burning so hot they felt like they might fall off.

Hearing this, Xu Qingzhu leaned down and kissed her, then whispered close to her ear, "You just want to be lazy."

"What are you talking about?"

Between kisses, Liang Shi complained, "You're pregnant."

Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow. "You just want to be lazy."

That raised eyebrow looked like a provocation.

Liang Shi was helpless. She flipped over and sat up, her arm still resting on Xu Qingzhu's waist, and pinched her waist while she was at it. "Careful or I'll bite you."

The corners of Xu Qingzhu's eyes were already tinged with red, yet she still provoked, "Bite where?"

The moment her words fell, Liang Shi bit the side of her face.

Xu Qingzhu winced in pain. "Were you born in the Year of the Dog?"²

Liang Shi pushed the eye mask up to cover her eyes, and said matter-of-factly, "You told me to bite you."

Xu Qingzhu: ".....I told you to coax me....."

Before she could finish, her words were swallowed up.

Liang Shi took over her words, and while she was at it, undid the buttons of her pajamas.

"Isn't this coaxing you?" Liang Shi said softly. "My little ancestor."³

Her gentle voice carried a hint of indulgence.

Footnotes:

¹ **"I'm yours for the picking"** (任君采撷): A classical Chinese expression meaning "at your disposal" or "yours to pluck/pick as you wish." It's a poetic way of offering oneself, often with romantic or intimate connotations. The phrase originates from poetry about picking flowers or fruits.

² **"Were you born in the Year of the Dog?"** (你屬狗的啊): A Chinese expression used when someone bites you, referencing the Chinese zodiac. It's a playful complaint meaning "Why are you biting me like a dog?"

³ **"My little ancestor"** (祖宗): A Chinese term of endearment used sarcastically or affectionately when someone is being demanding or difficult to please. It literally means "ancestor" but is used to express "you're so hard to serve" in a doting way.